

Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

What the Crime Is:

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a type of cybercrime where scammers trick users into transferring money through fake payment requests, links, or QR codes.

How It Typically Happens (Step-by-Step):

1. The scammer contacts the victim through a phone call, SMS, or social media, pretending to be a bank official, seller, or customer.
2. They create urgency by offering rewards, refunds, or claiming a problem with the victim's account.
3. The victim is asked to click on a link, scan a QR code, or approve a "collect request."
4. Instead of receiving money, the victim unknowingly authorizes a payment.
5. The money is instantly transferred to the scammer's account and is difficult to recover.

Who Is Usually Targeted:

Beginners, elderly people, small business owners, and first-time digital payment users are the most common targets because they may not fully understand how UPI transactions work.

Consequences:

Victims may lose their savings within seconds. In addition to financial loss, it can lead to stress, loss of trust in digital platforms, and sometimes identity misuse if personal details are shared.

Conclusion:

This case highlights the importance of digital awareness. Users should never approve unknown requests, share OTPs, or scan QR codes to receive money. Staying alert is the best defense against such fraud.